

GitHub Copilot in Positron

International Marketing Analytics

WIRTSCHAFTS UNIVERSITÄT WIEN VIENNA UNIVERSITY OF ECONOMICS AND BUSINESS

Dr Arne Floh, Senior Lecturer in Marketing
WU Vienna, Institute for International Business

arne.floh@wu.ac.at
Office hours: book online (Google Calendar)

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SESSION 1 · WT 2026/27

Today: an AI assistant in your analysis

Get Copilot → Connect → Chat → Complete code → Use it well → Fix problems

On github.com

- Copilot Free today
- Copilot Student once GitHub Education approves you
- Privacy settings

In Positron

- Connect Copilot as a model provider
- Chat with Posit Assistant
- Accept or reject code completions

Your job

- Check every number
- No personal data in prompts
- Log your prompts for the course

You stay in charge: the assistant proposes, you decide, run and check.

Positron Assistant is now Posit Assistant

2025.07	2025.10	2026.04	2026.07	2026.10
Positron Assistant (preview)	Copilot also for chat	Posit Assistant (preview)	Posit Assistant default; old one removed	current Positron release

Positron: the free editor by Posit, where you write and run Python

Posit Assistant: the AI chat built into Positron; it has no model of its own

GitHub Copilot: the model provider: it answers in the chat and suggests code



Old tutorials? Ask/Edit/Agent modes or positron.assistant.enable mean the guide is outdated.

What Copilot does in Positron

Provider	Chat	Completions	Cost for you
GitHub Copilot (Preview)	yes	yes, ghost text	free with Copilot Student or Free
Posit AI Pass	yes	yes	20 USD a month
Anthropic, OpenAI, others	yes	no	paid API key

Chat

Ask, plan, run code after your OK, explain errors

Completions

Grey suggestions while you type; Tab accepts

For this course: GitHub Copilot. It costs nothing with GitHub Education.

Get GitHub Copilot

Part 1 of 6 · the free plans, activating Copilot
Student, privacy settings

Two free Copilot plans

	Copilot Free	Copilot Student
Who	anyone with a GitHub account	verified students (GitHub Education)
Code completions	2,000 a month	unlimited
Chat and agent	an allowance of AI credits	a larger allowance of AI credits
Models	automatic selection only	automatic selection only
Price	free	free while you study

Credits run out? they reset on the 1st of the month. The Copilot icon in Positron's status bar shows how much you have used.

Activate Copilot Student

Copilot Student

1 **Be verified** in GitHub Education (see GitHub deck, Part 2)

2 Open github.com/settings/education/benefits

3 **Under Free GitHub developer resources:** Learn more

4 **Follow the prompts** to activate Copilot Student

5 **Check** github.com/settings/copilot

Not approved yet?

- Use Copilot Free meanwhile
- github.com/settings/copilot → Start using Copilot Free
- Shown a paid checkout? Do not pay; wait a few days

Re-checked monthly: the free plan ends when you are no longer a student.

Privacy settings on github.com

Opt out of model training

1 Open github.com/settings/copilot

2 **Find** Allow GitHub to use my data for AI model training

3 **Set it to** Disabled

4 **Done:** the setting saves at once

Posit does not see your prompts

GitHub / Microsoft receive prompt and context

Their terms apply to what you send

Rule: send code and anonymised data only. Names, e-mails, customer IDs and confidential files never go into a prompt.

Connect Copilot to Positron

Part 2 of 6 · check the version, sign in, test that it works

Before you start

1. **Positron 2026.07 or later:** Help → Check for Updates (current: 2026.10)
2. **Open your project folder:** File → Open Folder
3. **Trust the folder** when Positron asks: Yes, I trust the authors
4. **Python running:** pick Python 3.14 (.venv) at the top right
5. **GitHub account** with Copilot Free or Copilot Student active



Nothing to switch on: AI is ready; it waits for a provider.

Connect GitHub Copilot

In Positron

1. **Command Palette:** Ctrl/Cmd + Shift + P
2. **Type and run:** Authentication: Configure Language Model Providers
3. **Pick** GitHub Copilot
4. **Sign in** in the browser, click Authorize
5. **Back in Positron:** Copilot shows as connected

Command Palette

```
Authentication:
  Configure Language
  Model Providers
```

Shortcut

- Accounts menu (person icon, bottom left)
- → Configure Language Model Providers

Signed in to GitHub, but no Copilot? you must use Configure Language Model Providers.

Check that it works

Connected: the provider dialog shows GitHub Copilot as connected

Chat: View: Show Posit Assistant opens; Copilot models in the model picker

Ghost text: typing in a .py file or a Quarto code cell shows grey suggestions

Status bar: the Copilot icon at the bottom shows your usage

Report: Command Palette → AI: Create Diagnostic Report

All five fine? you are ready.

If the browser does not return to Positron

Sign in with a device code

1. **Settings:** search preferDeviceCodeFlow, tick it
2. **Run again:** Configure Language Model Providers
3. **Dialog shows** Your Code: e.g. 4F2A-91C7
4. **Click** Copy & Continue to Browser
5. **Paste the code** on GitHub, click Authorize

Still stuck?

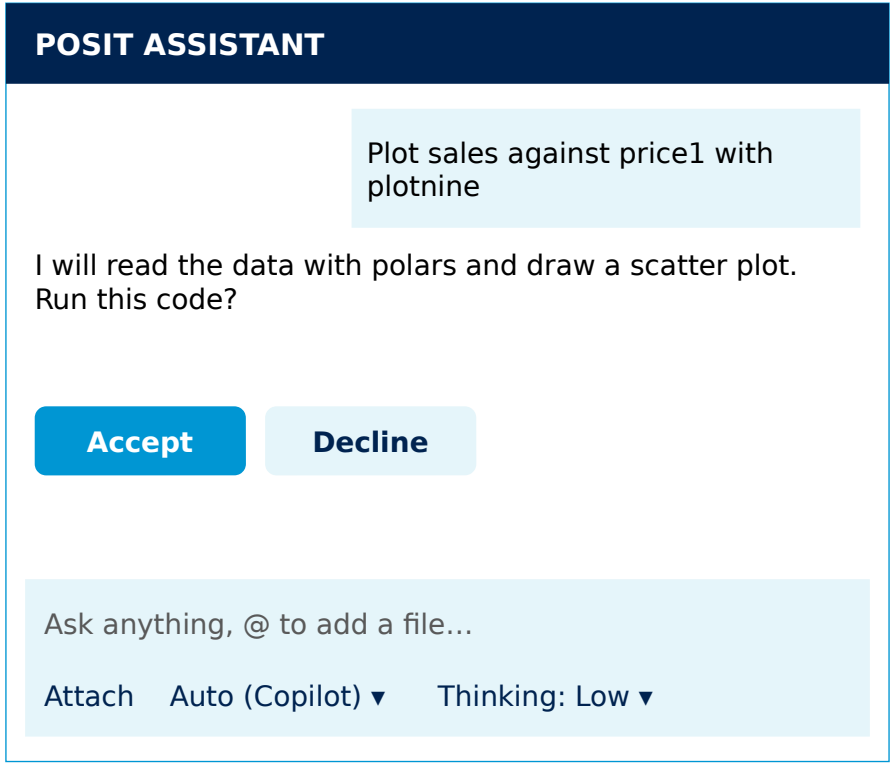
- Accounts → Manage Accounts: sign out, sign in again
- Check Copilot is active on github.com/settings/copilot
- Restart Positron

University or company network? proxies can block the redirect; the device code usually works.

Chat with Posit Assistant

Part 3 of 6 · the pane, what it sees,
permissions, slash commands, Fix and Explain

The Posit Assistant pane



1 Open it
activity-bar icon or View: Show Posit Assistant

2 Your request
plain English; name files, packages, outputs

3 Accept / Decline
nothing runs without your OK

4 @ and paperclip
add files, images or the .qmd you work on

5 Model and thinking
Auto with Copilot; more thinking = slower, more careful

What Posit Assistant can see

Your session

- Python version
- Variable names and types
- Data-frame columns and shape

Your output

- Plots
- Console history
- Errors

Your files

- Open files and selection
- Project folder structure
- Files you attach

Tip: load the data first, then ask; the assistant sees the column names and gets them right

Keep files out: setting positron.assistant.aiExcludes, e.g. data/personal/**

It sees what you see: never load personal data you may not share.

It asks before it runs code

Mode	What happens	For you
Normal (default)	safe actions run; risky ones ask first	use this
Restricted	every action asks first	fine, automatic in untrusted folders
Plan (/plan)	writes a plan, changes nothing until you approve	good for bigger tasks
Ask (/ask)	answers only, read-only	good for questions
Auto, YOLO	approves actions automatically	do not use

Before you click Accept: read the code. Does it use polars, the right file and the right columns? If not, Decline and say what to change.

Slash commands, Fix and Explain

Type	What it does
/new	start a new conversation (new topic)
/plan	plan first, code later
/ask	questions only, no changes
/report	turn the chat into a Quarto .qmd
/notebook	export the chat to a notebook

Error in the Console

```
ColumnNotFoundError:
  unable to find column "Sales"
```

Fix **Explain**

Explain first: understand the error, then fix it yourself or with Fix.

Learning tip: use Explain more than Fix. You will meet the same error in the exam, without the assistant.

Example: the chocolate data

Your prompt

```
Use polars, not pandas, to read
data/legacy/chocolate_dataset.csv.
Plot sales against price1 with
plotnine. Fit sales ~ price1 with the
statsmodels formula API. Explain
each step in two sentences.
```

Then

1. **Read** the plan and code
2. **Accept** if it fits
3. **Check:** slope ≈ −669, R^2 ≈ 0.88
4. **Ask** why, if unsure

Names the file so it reads the right data

Names the packages so the code matches the course: polars, plotnine, statsmodels

✓ **Same numbers as on the slides?** then the code is right.

Code completions

Part 4 of 6 · ghost text, keys, switching it on and off

Ghost text: accept, take part, or ignore

```
choc = pl.read_csv(path)
model = smf.ols("sales ~ price1", data=choc
.to_pandas()).fit()
```

Grey text = Copilot's suggestion, not yet in your file

Key	Effect
Tab	accept the whole suggestion
Ctrl/Cmd + →	accept word by word
Esc or keep typing	ignore it
**Alt/Option + **	ask for a suggestion

Tab is not a reflex: read the grey text first. It guesses from patterns and can pick the wrong column, file or method.

Where: .py files and Quarto code cells; not in plain text or Markdown prose

Switch completions on and off

Quick: the status bar

1. **Click** the Copilot icon at the bottom
2. **Choose:** off for this file type, or all files
3. **Or:** Snooze Inline Suggestions for a while

settings.json: off for Python only

```
"github.copilot.enable": {
  "*": true,
  "python": false,
  "markdown": false
}
```

Learning a new method? turn completions off while you practise; switch them on when you work on the case study.

Use it well

Part 5 of 6 · good prompts, checking results,
data protection and course rules

Prompts that work

Weak

- “Analyse my data.”
- “Make a chart.”

Strong

- “Use polars to read data/case/orders.csv and plot weekly orders by country with plotnine.”

1. **Name the file, the packages and the output** you want
2. **Say polars** explicitly: the assistant often defaults to pandas
3. **Ask it to explain** each step, or the assumptions of a model
4. **One topic per chat:** /new for the next one

Check everything

Run it

- Run the code yourself
- Does it render from top to bottom?

Compare

- Numbers against the output
- Columns against the data

Understand

- Can you explain each line?
- Is it the method we learned?

Typical slips: pandas instead of polars, a wrong column, the wrong test, invented numbers

Numbers in text: always from inline code, never typed from the chat

You own every number: the assistant cannot be blamed in a report or an exam.

Data protection and course rules

Never in a prompt

- Names, e-mails, student or customer IDs
- Passwords, API keys
- Confidential or licensed data
- Other students' work

Course rules

- AI use is allowed and encouraged
- Prompt log: exercises and case study appendix
- You verify and own every result
- Exam: closed book, no AI

Prompt log: copy the prompts that produced non-trivial code, and note what you kept or changed.

Fix problems

Part 6 of 6 · common problems, outdated instructions, checklist

When it does not work

Problem	Fix
No Posit Assistant	Update Positron (2026.07+); trust the folder; View: Show Posit Assistant
Signed in to GitHub, no Copilot	Configure Language Model Providers → GitHub Copilot
No ghost text	status-bar icon: not snoozed or off; file is .py or a code cell
Usage limit reached	wait until the 1st; activate Copilot Student
Paid checkout on github.com	do not pay; wait a few days, try github.com/settings/copilot
Odd answers	add context (files, packages), or start again with /new

Diagnose: Command Palette → AI: Create Diagnostic Report.

Old instructions, and what to use now

If a guide says	Use now
Positron Assistant	Posit Assistant
Setting positron.assistant.enable	nothing to set (assistant.enabled is on)
Ask / Edit / Agent modes	Normal, /ask, /plan
Positron Assistant: Collect Diagnostics	AI: Create Diagnostic Report
Inline chat with Ctrl/Cmd + I	the Posit Assistant pane

Check the date: AI tools change monthly. Prefer positron.posit.co and GitHub Docs over older blog posts.

Checklist

1. **Copilot Free or Student** active on github.com/settings/copilot
2. **Model training** opt-out set to Disabled
3. **Positron 2026.07 or later,** project folder trusted
4. **Copilot connected:** Configure Language Model Providers
5. **Posit Assistant** answers, and ghost text appears in a code cell
6. **Prompt log** started for the coding exercise

Official guides

- Posit Assistant in Positron
- Getting started and model providers
- Code completions
- AI configuration and privacy settings
- Set up Copilot for students (GitHub Docs)
- Copilot plans
- Positron release notes

VIENNA UNIVERSITY OF ECONOMICS AND BUSINESS

INSTITUTE FOR INTERNATIONAL BUSINESS
Welthandelsplatz 1, 1020 Vienna, Austria

DR ARNE FLOH
Senior Lecturer in Marketing

F +43-31336-6367
arne.floh@wu.ac.at
www.wu.ac.at/en/welthandel/arne-floh
Office hours: book online